

Social Science Fair Interview 01

Transcript: Value and Pressure of Football Defenders

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Transcript Metadata

Project Theme:	Discussion on the Value and Pressure of Football Defenders
Date of Interview:	Thursday, May 28, 2026
Time of Interview:	19:52 – 20:04 (GMT+08)
Interviewer Identifier:	Speaker 100 Luke Sun
Interviewee Identifier:	Speaker 200 (██████████)
Interviewee Subject Profile:	School Team Athlete (Right-Back)

Official Verbatim Transcript

- 1 **Speaker 100 [00:01]:** Alright, you are ██████████, correct?
- 2 **Speaker 200 [00:04]:** Yes, I am.
- 3 **Speaker 100 [00:06]:** Okay. What position do you currently play on the school team?
- 4 **Speaker 200 [00:10]:** I mainly play right-back. That position, yes.
- 5 **Speaker 100 [00:14]:** And how do you define your core responsibility on the pitch? What do
6 you primarily do, roughly?
- 7 **Speaker 200 [00:21]:** Simply put, it's getting the ball, kicking it away, and passing it to the
8 players upfront so they can attack. To put it more complexly, when an opportunity arises, I
9 intercept the ball and organize the transition from the backfield to the frontfield. Additionally,
10 when the opponent attacks, we form a second line of defense to disrupt their offense.
- 11 **Speaker 100 [00:45]:** In the last match, how much of a decisive role do you think you played
12 in the team's victory or defeat?
- 13 **Speaker 200 [00:52]:** I feel my role in the outcome wasn't huge, but I still feel there was
14 some. Well, that's a bit of nonsense first, but I think the main reason is that I played for a
15 relatively short time; I played for a bit and then got substituted off. However, I think I was
16 useful because when I was playing, I helped absorb a lot of pressure for the center-backs, which
17 maintained our defensive advantage.
- 18 **Speaker 100 [01:28]:** Understood. When your mistake leads to the team conceding a goal,
19 do you feel intense pressure from your teammates, the coach, or the spectators? As a defender,
20 because you missed a ball and caused a concession, you must have experienced that, right?
- 21 **Speaker 200 [01:45]:** Yes.

22 **Speaker 100 [01:46]:** Do you feel the pressure from them is heavy?

23 **Speaker 200 [01:51]:** I feel the pressure from them is quite heavy. Although I am inherently
 24 a pressure-free person—when others put pressure on me, I don’t really convert it into internal
 25 friction or things like that—I feel their pressure helps me realize where I need to improve, rather
 26 than making me anxious about which direction I haven’t done better in.

27 **Speaker 100 [02:20]:** Okay. When the team wins, to what extent do you feel the credit is
 28 attributed to your performance on the defensive line? And to what extent is it seen as the
 29 performance of the attacking line, or the result of a collective team effort?

30 **Speaker 200 [02:33]:** I feel it’s more like the result of a collective team effort. Because in a
 31 football match, both defense and offense are very important, right? Although some Champions
 32 League teams might not agree, I still believe that winning is the collective outcome of the entire
 33 team acting as a unified entity, including the substitutes on the bench. Their encouragement
 34 gives the players on the field more fighting spirit, which also plays a certain role. So, no matter
 35 who it is, everyone is indispensable.

36 **Speaker 100 [03:10]:** Um, okay. Do you feel that defensive players face harsher criticism and
 37 negative attention than attacking players?

38 **Speaker 200 [03:21]:** I feel this is a very common issue. For example, if you, as the defense,
 39 lose the ball, the opponent has a very high probability of scoring. But if you, as the offense, lose
 40 the ball, it merely gives the opponent an attacking opportunity. It doesn’t directly lead to a
 41 highly irreversible consequence for the team. To give a more extreme example, when the game
 42 is intense and tied, going into extra time, if the backfield loses a ball at this moment, leading
 43 to an opponent’s goal, it is very difficult for our side to score again in such a short time. But if
 44 the offense loses the ball, the defense can still win it back.

45 **Speaker 100 [04:13]:** In post-match summaries or daily discussions, do you talk more often
 46 about statistics like goals and assists, or data like passing under pressure or critical tackles from
 47 defenders?

48 **Speaker 200 [04:26]:** I feel if a critical tackle looks exceptionally cool, people will definitely
 49 talk about it, but generally speaking, it’s still about things like goals.

50 **Speaker 100 [04:35]:** Um, do you feel your defensive contribution is somewhat undervalued
 51 because it’s hard to quantify like the number of goals?

52 **Speaker 200 [04:45]:** Not really, because I feel if I defend and our team wins, I feel my defense
 53 at least helped my team. If I keep defending and the opponent pours in 5 goals, then I feel I’m
 54 just purely bad, and there’s nothing more to say.

55 **Speaker 100 [05:03]:** In the market, they usually count goals and assists. You rarely see
 56 people counting clearances—there are some, but the attention isn’t that high—and things like
 57 tackle counts are even rarer. Do you think this current situation leads to the undervaluation of
 58 players’ worth? That is, will players who lean towards being defensive-minded be undervalued?

59 **Speaker 200 [05:26]:** I feel they will be. For instance—actually, I don’t have that many
 60 examples because I watch less football now—but I remember, for example, Piqué from Barcelona
 61 in 16/17, he was a center-back. But he defended exceptionally well as a center-back. Although
 62 it was largely attributed to his tall stature and excellent technique, I personally feel their success
 63 in that season drew heavily from the success of the backline. However, over those years, the
 64 main credit went to Messi. It’s not that Messi wasn’t good; Messi indeed could single-handedly
 65 carry the attacking side and score many goals, which is truly strong. But you have to know
 66 that in football, the pressure exerted on the defense is usually greater than the pressure applied
 67 to the offense. Because when we play, the offense losing two or three chances to get one or two
 68 goals is very worthwhile. But for the defense, if the opponent gets two or three chances and

69 scores a goal, it feels terrible.

70 **Speaker 100 [06:38]:** Oh, right. Then do you think this potential undervaluation, whether
71 amateur or professional, affects a player's status or confidence in the team? For example, you
72 potentially face this kind of undervaluation, right? Do you feel that way?

73 **Speaker 200 [06:58]:** Actually, I feel my situation is quite special, but I do feel a little bit,
74 because I transitioned from midfield.

75 **Speaker 100 [07:04]:** Then do you think this potential undervaluation has affected your status
76 or confidence in the team?

77 **Speaker 200 [07:13]:** It hasn't really affected my confidence. As for status, to put it bluntly,
78 I didn't have much status to begin with. But personally, I think the change in status wasn't
79 very big. Of course, I feel it decreased slightly because, in terms of impact on the game, I
80 personally believe transitioning from midfield to right-back reduced my ability to influence the
81 pitch. Although this change might be better for the team, so it doesn't matter.

82 **Speaker 100 [07:48]:** Um, okay, okay. As mentioned earlier, a backfield player losing the
83 ball often leads to a direct goal, while a frontfield player losing the ball can be won back,
84 representing a relatively lower risk. We call this the asymmetry of risk. Do you think there is
85 any possibility to change this reality through specific measures, plans, or policies? For example,
86 promoting the art of defending by defenders more on the internet, or teaching it more in offline
87 football classrooms, encouraging less individual heroism and more teamwork, emphasizing that
88 one cannot just attack but must also balance defense. Do you think there are feasible measures
89 or plans like this?

90 **Speaker 200 [08:42]:** I feel if we want to balance the external pressure received by both sides,
91 it might be possible. For example, if one day, as you mentioned, we promote from the opposite
92 direction that the consequences of a forward losing the ball are more severe, and conduct
93 campaigns through public opinion, then the pressure itself will become more balanced. But if
94 you are talking about reducing the pressure on defenders, I feel the change won't be significant.
95 Because a defender losing the ball and causing a defeat is a hard event. You basically cannot
96 change this fact through external promotion.

97 **Speaker 200 [09:27]:** Right? Because it is inherently the fact that a goal was scored. Struc-
98 turally speaking, defending is easier than attacking. So when you are attacking, losing the ball
99 a bit more is considered normal by people. If you try to level it out by adjusting external
100 expectations, to be honest, the gap between the blame carried for conceding a goal and the
101 blame carried for losing the ball in the frontfield will still remain.

102 **Speaker 100 [10:03]:** Then are there any specific measures to level out this expectation? Have
103 you thought of any?

104 **Speaker 200 [10:12]:** The first one that comes to mind right now is using the previous method
105 of online public opinion. Another way, I feel, is to improve the overall level of the defensive line
106 itself. For example, a three-man backline and a four-man backline are different. From another
107 perspective, if a three-man backline concedes a goal, the blame is shared equally among these
108 three people—excluding individual situations of who missed the ball, of course. If it's a four-
109 man backline and a goal is conceded, this situation will be attributed to either the opponent
110 being too strong, in which case it doesn't matter if there are three or four people, or all four of
111 us sharing the blame simultaneously. In this case, the pressure will be distributed more evenly
112 and won't be as high.

113 **Speaker 100 [11:09]:** So what are the specific measures?

114 **Speaker 200 [11:11]:** First, have defenders train more. Second, add more defenders.

115 **Speaker 100 [11:18]:** Add more defenders.

116 **Speaker 200 [11:20]:** That means strengthening the defensive capability of the team itself.
117 By changing the hard strength, we reduce the probability of being overwhelmed by pressure.

118 **Speaker 100 [11:33]:** Okay, okay, okay, thank you. That's all.

Translated from Chinese.